SPORTS ▼

BEYOND THE FINISH LINE

After his second Winter Olympics stint, **Arif Mohammad Khan** wants to mentor the next generation

Arif Mohammad Khan knows what it means to be a lone soldier. At the just-concluded Milano Cortina Winter Olympics, the Kashmiri skier was one of India's only two representatives and also the flag-bearer at the opening ceremony. Competing in his second consecutive Olympics, Khan improved on his Beijing performance to finish 39th in slalom in what was also India's best-ever finish in the event. "The intent is to uplift Jammu & Kashmir youth, tell them we have the ability to go on a global platform. I want more athletes from the valley enrolled in winter sports," says Khan.

He almost didn't make it, having to rely on crowdfunding and the support of JSW Sports. "They covered 30-40 per cent of my expenses. The Government of India also took some initiative," he notes. That athletes like Khan have to raise the resources to represent India after earning their Olympic spot is symptomatic of the systemic malaise that envelops winter sports in India. As an athlete with nearly two decades of experience under his belt, he

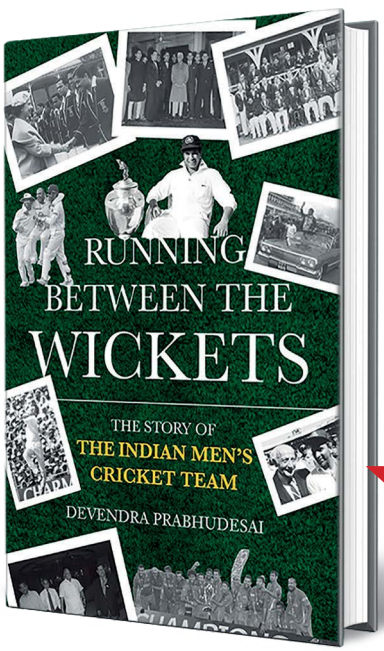
ALREADY 35, KHAN PERHAPS KNOWS THAT TO BE THERE FOUR YEARS LATER IN THE FRENCH ALPS MAY BE A TOUGH SUMMIT TO REACH



BOOKS ▼

The Edge Called Tea

Devendra Prabhudesai presents a detailed and fact-driven account of



RUNNING BETWEEN THE WICKETS
By Devendra Prabhudesai
RUPA
₹495; 352 pages

The history of Indian cricket can be written in many ways: as a factual recitation of events and dates, as a commentary against the background of political and cultural changes, as biographies of its leading lights, as a way of understanding 'Indianness' by stating, as the author does, that "1932 (when India played their first Test) is not very different from 2025".

Prabhudesai has chosen each of these approaches in varying degrees, with the emphasis on the first. He knows the oral history well, and has read the written ones. A stint as the BCCI's manager, media relations and corporate affairs, has given him both access and insight into men and matters. Written in a chatty, informal style, the book will be particularly useful for the IPL generation and those who believe that history began with Virat Kohli or Rohit Sharma.

The author's love for the game comes through, but also leads him to make somewhat exaggerated claims, like when he says the president of Bombay's Hindu Gymkhana "was emboldened to make a subtle appeal to the British to start treating their Indian subjects fairly only because of the way Nayudu had batted against a team representing the rulers". This, about